Fractures, contusions and sprains

Fractures, contusions and sprains are among the most frequent injuries resulting from accidents, falls or sudden movements. They can range from mild forms to serious situations that require immediate medical intervention.

Knowing how to recognise these injuries and how to provide first aid is essential in order to prevent them from getting worse and to ensure a faster recovery.

What fractures, contusions and sprains are

- A **fracture** is the total or partial breaking of a bone. It can be closed or open, depending on whether the skin is affected.
- **Contusions** (bruises) are injuries to the soft tissues, without damage to the bone, that occur as a result of a direct impact.
- **Sprains** occur when the ligaments of a joint are stretched or torn, usually following a sudden movement or a twist. The most common are ankle sprains.

Signs and symptoms

Fractures manifest themselves through intense pain, deformation of the affected area, inability to move it and swelling. Sometimes bleeding or abnormal positions of the limb may also appear.

Contusions manifest themselves through localised pain, swelling and the appearance of bruises.

Sprains are characterised by pain at the level of the joint, swelling, difficulty in moving and sometimes instability of the joint.

The dangers of these injuries

Fractures can become dangerous if they are moved, as they may damage blood vessels or nerves. In the case of open fractures, there is also a risk of infection.

Untreated sprains can lead to weakening of the joint and to repeated injuries. Even if they appear milder, they still require attention. Contusions can hide more serious injuries, especially if the pain persists.

First aid in case of fractures

In the case of a fracture, the affected area must be immobilised immediately, using splints or rigid objects. The person should not be moved unnecessarily.

If there is bleeding, it must be stopped by applying a dressing. Medical help must be requested as quickly as possible.

First aid in case of contusions

The affected area must be kept at rest. Applying a cold compress helps to reduce pain and inflammation. It is important to monitor the evolution of the injury. If the symptoms get worse, a doctor must be consulted.

First aid in case of sprains

In the case of sprains, it is important to avoid putting weight on the affected joint. Rest and the application of cold compresses are recommended in order to reduce the swelling. The joint can be wrapped with an elastic bandage for support, and the affected limb should be kept elevated whenever possible.

What should be avoided

Repositioning the bones in the case of fractures should not be attempted. Also, heat must not be applied immediately after the injury, because this can make the inflammation worse.